

Hamas agrees to return hostages

Group holds back on other terms of Trump peace plan, including a call for it to disarm.

By NABIH BULOS

JERUSALEM — Hamas on Friday accepted most of President Trump’s terms for ending the war in Gaza, delivering a “Yes, but ...” response that agreed to handing over all hostages and relinquishing control of the enclave, but stopped short of the full surrender outlined in the agreement.

The response came the day Trump said that the Palestinian militant group had until Sunday to accept what was essentially a take-it-or-leave-it ultimatum.

“If this LAST CHANCE agreement is not reached, then all HELL, like no one has ever seen before, will break out against Hamas,” wrote Trump on his messaging platform, Truth Social.

After days of what it said was “thorough study” — and intense pressure from its Arab interlocutors in Qatar, Egypt and others — Hamas issued a statement late Friday saying it would release all Israeli hostages, dead or alive, according to “the exchange formula outlined in President Trump’s proposal, provided that field conditions for carrying out the exchange are secured.”

Trump’s deal, which comprises 20 points and amounts to more of a framework than a comprehensive agreement, represents his administration’s most concerted push to not only end the Hamas-Israel war, but achieve a more comprehensive peace in the region.

Upon acceptance from both sides, the agreement says, hostilities must immediately end and aid be allowed into Gaza, where Israel [See **Hamas**, A4]



CREWS attempt to extinguish a large fire after an explosion at Chevron refinery in El Segundo on Thursday.

ALLEN J. SCHABEN Los Angeles Times

Massive blast at refinery raises worries

Cause of Chevron fire that rocked South Bay remains unknown as investigation begins.

By CLARA HARTER, GRACE TOOHEY, RUBEN VIVES, TONY BRISCOE AND CONNOR SHEETS

Mark Rogers was mid-dribble at a South Bay soccer field Thursday evening when he was shocked to see a ball of gas and fire explode into the night sky.

Residents across the South Bay ran outside to find a neon orange hue covering the horizon accompanied by a loud roar as a major fire at the Chevron refinery in El Segundo grew. Guests at Top Golf saw massive flames billowing across the Pacific Coast Highway and ran to their cars.

“I thought we got nuked or something,” Rogers, 34, said.

For about 30 minutes, the whirling fire could be heard for miles around, while its orange glow reached even farther. But just as quickly as the fire exploded, it came under control, and by Friday morning life had mostly returned to normal, with locals walking their dogs and a few surfers carrying their boards in the shadow of the refinery.

Local officials said the blast, while dramatic, did not pose a threat to the public and emergency workers from both local cities and Chevron were able to quickly get the situation under control. Chevron and a union representing plant workers reported no injuries from the blast, and the sprawling refinery — one of the largest in the nation — looked no worse for wear, at least from the outside.

But the blast left many questions about what went wrong. At least one worker claimed in a lawsuit filed Friday that he was injured in the fire, though the suit did not include specifics. His lawyer alleged the fire was a “preventable disaster” that occurred because plant operators cut corners.

There were also lingering questions about how the incident might affect local air quality and gas prices.

The blaze originated in a processing unit in the southeast corner of the refinery, El Segundo officials said. The Occupational Safety and Health Administration and the South Coast Air Quality Management District have responded to the incident. Chevron will investigate the cause of the fire.

Chevron released a statement calling it an “isolated fire” and said that “all refinery personnel and contractors have been accounted for and there are no injuries.” [See **Refinery**, A6]

Prices at the pump to surge after fire

How long refinery is out of operation could determine how much pain is coming. **BUSINESS, A10**

Audit of \$4-billion abuse settlement urged

Lawmakers and labor leaders demand action after Times finds plaintiffs who say they were paid to sue L.A. County

By REBECCA ELLIS

California lawmakers, local officials and labor leaders are demanding an audit of Los Angeles County’s historic \$4-billion sex abuse settlement as well as a State Bar investigation into a law firm that represents thousands of alleged victims.

The call follows a Los Angeles Times investigation that revealed some plaintiffs in the largest sex abuse settlement in U.S. history said vendors paid them cash to sue the county, with two telling The Times that vendors instructed them to fabricate the claims. All of the plaintiffs in the report had lawsuits filed by Downtown LA Law Group, or DTLA, a personal injury firm with more than 2,700 cases in the settlement.

DTLA denied it had any involvement with vendors, who some plaintiffs said paid them to file suit, and The Times could not reach the vendors for comment.

A majority of the Los Angeles County Board of Supervisors expressed outrage.

“I’m disgusted,” said Supervisor Kathryn Barger, the chair of the board, which



AL SEIB For The Times

COUNTY Supervisor Janice Hahn said any attorney guilty of paying for plaintiffs “should be disbarred.”

approved the settlement this April. “It is appalling that dishonest lawyers and individuals would exploit reforms that were meant to deliver justice to survivors of abuse. ... I am calling for a full investigation into these allegations.”

DTLA has categorically denied paying people to sue and said no representative of the firm had been authorized to make payments. The firm said it has hired a “third-party neutral” to determine whether any false claims had been filed.

“The allegations in this story are extremely concerning and describe conduct that is contrary to our firm’s values,” read the statement. “While we do not believe they are accurate, we are taking them seriously.”

The Times investigation found seven plaintiffs who said they were paid by “recruiters” for a law firm outside a county social services office in South Los Angeles.

California law bans a practice known as capping, in which non-attorneys directly solicit or procure clients to sign up for lawsuits [See **Settlement**, A6]

A confusing law for denser housing

By JACK FLEMMING AND DAVID ZAHNISR

When Brendon Gerisch and his wife searched for a new home, they knew they wanted something with a little privacy — a backyard, some fully grown trees, less crowded surroundings.

The couple thought they found their “forever home” in L.A.’s Westchester neighborhood, buying a four-bedroom in 2018 on a quiet street with one-story houses.

Now, he’s not so sure. Landmark legislation now on Gov. Gavin Newsom’s desk would “upzone” his and scores of other neighborhoods across California, allowing the construction of residential buildings as tall as nine stories, depending on how close they are to a rail station.

State Senate Bill 79, one of the most significant pieces of housing legislation in decades, seeks to address California’s housing crisis by boosting production near public transit stops — [See **Housing**, A9]

Bill awaiting Newsom’s OK would allow up to nine-story towers near transit. Communities are worried, unsure how it would affect them.



CARLIN STIEHL Los Angeles Times

BRENDON GERISCH of Westchester doesn’t want his area to become crowded with mid-rise buildings.

Combs sentenced to 50 months, capping ex-mogul’s downfall

Judge says music figure showed ‘no remorse’ for his crime and tacks on a fine of \$500,000.

By RICHARD WINTON

A judge sentenced Sean “Diddy” Combs to four years and two months in federal prison Friday for transporting prostitutes across state lines for drug-fueled sex performances he dubbed “freak-offs,” closing the chapter on the music mogul’s years-long public downfall.

In sentencing Combs to 50 months in prison — of which he’s required to serve 85% — U.S. District Judge Arun Subramanian said that “exploitation and violence against women must be met with real account-

ability to promote respect for the law.”

Combs’ reputation and business began to publicly unravel in November 2023. He was sued by ex-girlfriend Casandra “Cassie” Ventura, federal authorities searched his homes, and a video was leaked to the media showing him beating Ventura in a Los Angeles hotel years earlier.

The following September, Combs was charged with serious crimes, including running a mob-style criminal enterprise that could have put him in prison for life. However, in July a jury acquitted him on the most serious charges and convicted him of two counts of transporting prostitutes across state lines. On Friday, Subramanian said testimony at trial played a role in Combs’ fate.

[See **Combs**, A12]

Upstart poised to take over hallowed CBS News

By STEPHEN BATTAGLIO

CBS News will learn a lot about its future next week when Bari Weiss, founder of the upstart news site the Free Press, is expected to enter the hallowed halls where Walter Cronkite and Mike Wallace once roamed.

Weiss, 41, is joining CBS News in a new role of editor in chief, according to people familiar with the discussions who were not authorized to

comment publicly. The appointment could be announced as soon as Monday.

David Ellison, 42, chairman and chief executive of CBS owner Paramount, approached Weiss months ago, part of his campaign to shake things up. She will report to Ellison and work alongside CBS News President Tom Cibrowski, who joined the network in February.

Under the deal, Paramount has agreed to buy

Weiss’ four-year-old digital media business, which offers newsletters, reported pieces, podcasts and what it calls “sense-making columns,” for around \$150 million in cash and stock. For months, her anticipated arrival at CBS News, an aging pillar of the press establishment, has been a hot topic in the news business.

The rapid rise of Weiss — a former newspaper opinion page staff editor — to a major role in shaping the cov-

erage of a TV news organization with no previous experience in the medium is an extraordinary move that is likely to be highly scrutinized.

Will she remold the news division — which has been beset by management turnover and sustained pressure from President Trump — in her image? There will also be questions as to whether the founder of a relatively lean digital operation such as the [See **Weiss**, A11]

Details of girl found in car a mystery
Lake Elsinore mourns teen whose body was discovered in trunk of singer D4vd’s Tesla. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Justices to take up key gun case
Several states prohibit firearms at private places that are open to the public. **NATION, A5**

Weather
Sunny.
L.A. Basin: 80/58. **B8**

Markets A12
Opinion Voices A13

Betts refocuses, saves his season
With new mindset, he is back in offensive groove as Dodgers face Phillies in NLDS. **SPORTS, B12**

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